

ILR dreams of a Pyrrhic victory





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The Ken-Betwa is among the 30 interlinking of rivers (ILR) projects which were conceived in the eighties and nineties. The idea is to interlink rivers across the country to create a “water grid”.

After years of meandering through the judicial and legislative maze, the NDA government expedited the work on the ILR programme despite the Central Empowered Committee of the Supreme Court raising serious concerns about the environmental impact of the project, the destruction of large swathes of the Panna Tiger Reserve and the loss of thousands of trees.

“I see no merit (in ILR). How is it going to benefit marginal farmers, ecology or the displaced communities?” says Shailaja Deshpande of Jeevitnadi Living River Foundation, a Pune-based non-profit organisation.

Deshpande’s misgivings are not unfounded given that the programme does not consider the “climate change, water equality or ecological sustainability perspectives”.

With no thorough study of the impact of climate change, the ILR programme loses dynamism. Basins marked as “surplus” regions may not have the capacity to feed the “deficit” zones in the long run, as impacts of changing climatic conditions may create adversities.

Here, the case of Punjab can be cited. The state refused to share irrigation water with Haryana and Rajasthan through canals and passed the Punjab Termination of Agreements Bill, 2004, to annul a 1981 water-sharing pact. The argument was that the volume of Ravi-Beas water has reduced drastically over the years.

It is one of the many examples that show how not including climate change as a key variable in the dynamics of water-sharing and interlinking can lead to major socio-political conflicts across the country.

"There is a model, called the water allocation model, where it looks at how climate change will alter the availability of water. I don't think the scientific model is being well-integrated into the planning," said Harini Santhanam, associate professor of Environmental Science at Manipal Academy of Higher Education, about the Ken-Betwa project.

Echoing Santhanam, Rajarshi Das Bhowmik, assistant professor at the Interdisciplinary Centre for Water Research, Indian Institute of Science, says neither the long-term impact of climate change nor the numerous scenarios arising out of the crisis has been thoroughly and systematically investigated.

Cost variables

The ILR programme is a hope, albeit bleak, for the future and not a promise for the present. Of the 30 links that NWDA identified in the nineties, only 11 have seen some progress. Of these, Ken-Betwa is the only live one. Considering the implementation momentum so far, this project may take over two to three decades to be completed.

The cost overruns in that case will be massive. In the case of Ken-Betwa, the cost has increased 2,100% (from Rs 2,000 crore to over Rs 44,000 crore) as the scope of the project has expanded.

This colossal financial burden will have to be borne by taxpayers and, in the long run, will affect essential developmental schemes in sectors such as healthcare and education.

According to water conservationist S Vishwanath, the cost and the environmental impact far override the benefits. Citing the example of the Yettinahole Integrated Drinking Water Supply Project in Karnataka, he says that "after spending Rs 20,000 crore, we do not have a drop of water".

"It is time we work more on local watersheds," he says.

There are also social and cultural costs involving the displaced population. According to Santhanam, loss of social stability due to displacement, culture, and traditional and indigenous knowledge, such as boat-making and fishing, are some of the aspects which are seldom considered.

"Also, there is an emotional cost (caused by climate change or displacement), and there is no parameter to measure it," she says.

These tangible and intangible costs make ILRs even more unfeasible, making consideration of "other options" imperative.

"Among the options are rainwater harvesting, groundwater recharge, watershed development, rejuvenation of local water bodies and optimisation of cropping patterns as the primary steps," says Himanshu Thakkar, coordinator at South Asia Network on Dams, Rivers & People.

Nomenclature ambiguities

The entire programme has several ambiguities in terms of nomenclatures. A major ambiguity is in describing the programme as a megaproject. Rectifying the misnomer, Vishwanath says it is a set of proposed interlinkings that are or will be implemented individually. The nomenclature in this case needs to be clarified, for this will define the cost estimation.

Second, saying that the programme will create a water grid, in the lines of a power grid, across the country is misleading. Unlike electricity, water flow is a one-way phenomenon. This argument is also raised by Amit Bhatnagar, who has been spearheading the protests against the Ken-Betwa project.

"The Ken River's source elevation is 550 m above sea level, while that of Betwa's is 576 m. So, how can water be channelled effectively from the lower to the upper elevation?" says Bhatnagar.

The last, and most important, is the usage of absolute terms like 'surplus' and 'deficit'. Once climate change is incorporated into the dynamics of the programme, these two absolutes become variables, making the benefits of ILRs even more difficult to define.

The crucial one of all the arguments is around environmental degradation. Bhatnagar says, despite the protests, work on the Ken-Betwa project has already begun, and about 30,000 trees have been felled.

"River linking would be an ecological disaster. Source regions' security depends on dense canopy and groundwater resources, which will be lost forever, making it more vulnerable to disasters. Forests will get submerged. Natural flows will be diverted or changed, leading to irreversible loss of river ecosystems," says Deshpande.

Rampant deforestation will adversely affect soil quality and groundwater reserves in the long run. Hence, this irreversible destruction is not only redundant but also a foolish move that will impede community development in the future.

Karnataka in focus

Of the 11 approved detailed project reports under the ILR programme, at least three are directly or indirectly related to Karnataka and the Cauvery. The state has seen protests similar to the Ken-Betwa link.

In 2022, local activists opposed the plan to interlink the Bedti and the Varada, saying the project would destroy 2,125 acres of forest area in the Western Ghats.

Karnataka is already embroiled in water disputes with Goa over the Mahadayi and Tamil Nadu over the Cauvery. The interlinking projects will further complicate the socio-politico-economic situation among the states.

IISc's Das Bhowmik points out that "water utility in the fast-growing urban pockets of the state has changed". But it is not clear how the ILR programme can align with the urban water requirements, though the Union Minister of State for the Ministry of Jal Shakti, Veeranna Somanna, is confident that the state-focused ILR projects will not only take care of irrigation but also benefit the cities.

Whether or not the ILR programme is the answer to the water woes of Karnataka and the rest of the country remains debatable, but it is safe to say that if achieved, it will be a Pyrrhic victory for generations to come.

However, that is barely a concern for our public representatives because currently, the ILR has become more a political show of strength than a debate on sustainable development.

(Disclaimer: The views expressed above are the author's own. They do not necessarily reflect the views of DH.)

